Chapter Ten

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Strategic Retreat

01

KATIYA

I take deep breaths as I try not to let him break me. Cody's gone now. And I will never have to deal with him again.

I dig my heels into the space between the floorboards, catching my breath as I drive my back against the closet door. My nails tension against the pad of my palm, leaving crescents in my flesh as the blood drains from my fingertips.

My heart can only take so much in a day. I thought the enemy could only strike when my presence was voluntary; when I patrol the borders of Gaffesend by my own volition. And it only took a day for this peaceful haven to be violated by a stranger.

I can't keep sitting here. The curse will catch me if I don't get up: the white feeling that tensions my hands and sets my body in full static. The shorter the time between those moments of frantic stillness, the easier it slides into that incontrovertible state of shock. It's addiction without a pleasure to be addicted to, and the more often that white feeling haunts

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me, the stronger it gets — so I'm glad when I find my effects are still scattered across the floor. A mess to clean is the second-best thing to distract me right now: the first is going to the bar, but after my episode, I'd rather not be seen in public.

I let my mind flow with visions of how I can transform this space into a place of respite, rather than feeling like an ephemeral halfway-house between training and the front lines. The mind is a vessel that can only hold so much at a time, so I drink to the the purity of those beautiful thoughts, driving down the opacity of fear's murky brine. The pale white feeling fades as the light begins to shine through, reaching my furthest depths.

When my hands stave off the static, I gather the courage to seal that passageway forever.

I let the Essence flood my circuits with enough heat to melt the handle of the closet door to the deadbolt, ensuring it's locked forever. Then I drag an empty bookcase across the floor to cover it. It irritates me that it's slightly spaced from the wall due to the protrusion of the melted handle, so I melt the rest of it, turning the balled handle into a flat plate pressed against the profile of the wooden door, deciding it's good enough to try to forget.

I lack the Auvryan magic of mind, but I hypnotize myself anyway.

The bookcase has always been here.

Next, I purge anything that reminds me of him.

I wipe his blood from the dagger. I return the fruit scattered across the floor into the bowl. I pull the kitchen knives from the overturned table and reset the tablecloth the other way around, covering the gaping holes in the wood. Finding the evidence is still in the fabric, I sew the clean cuts in the tablecloth closed with thread from my sewing kit. I mop and dab all the puddles and smudges. This leads to finding places for the hundred pounds of my unpacked personal items, placing them anywhere but the closet I should have forgotten, which leads to re-orienting all the decorations and furniture and bookshelf to make the space my own, which leads to dusting every surface I can find. Before long, I find my

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exasperated body sprawled across the kitchen's area rug, drugged by the excitement of exertion, staring at the cross-beams of the low wooden ceiling with a slight smile on my face.

I hoped so dearly that this distraction would let me forget.

But even still, I find the urge to reconcile that impossibility.

I need to keep moving. I need to find something to fix when I can't leave this house. Since I can't patch the dent in the wall, I decide to look harder for any dust that might coalesce beneath the cabinets. I roll over to find the duster did its job well, but there's something else tucked under there.

It's a strange, slender, rectangular object beneath the cutout of the kitchen cabinet. Like all the other things in his realm, it's perfectly smooth and square — but I can tell it's been worn from years and years of continuous use. It would look like an ingot if it wasn't so flat: hardly enough for a blacksmith to smelt it into anything. When I turn the heavy block in my hands, I find that I'm able to read the foreign words on the back, etched in white beneath an image of a bitten fruit:

LOVE YOU JACKIE D
FROM CODY 2010
MERRY CHRISTMAS
160 GB

A set of long, slender wires snake from the bottom of it, ending with white buds that look like they could grow into flowers. Does it work with electricity? Because it's certainly not plugged in to anything.

A light tug pulls out the buds by their roots. I panic for a second until I realize I'll never have to return this thing to him.

When I jam the buds' metal root back into the hole, the dark square on the front turns on, glowing with an impossible, radiant white, labeled with options in black.

It takes me a while to figure it out, but when my finger glides on the circle, the little window changes. I settle the black bar on PICTURES, expecting a photograph to dispense from the tiny slot in the bottom.

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I press the center button.

But instead, the window shows a gateway to an entirely different world. It reminds me of the moving projections that I heard were in the theatre rooms of the capital, though this one is so impossibly small — and there's not a creature in existence that could roll the image from inside. It reminds me of the screaming woman behind the window on the stranger's wall.

There's so many tiny squares of color that make this picture, but it's still hard to make out. Two people sit at a table in a stone-walled room lit by a very bright lamp. One is small: just a boy, and the other is older, wearing some kind of green-and-brown uniform — sharp enough in dress that I figure he's a warrior.

All I can tell is that they care for each other: sitting together building something metallic and square with wires hanging off of it. And they have this same device there, sharing the white buds between their ears.

I try the same with the round white shapes, but nothing happens. I click another button on the side. The screen goes black, reflecting my eyes on its worn, yet polished surface, and when I realize how time has passed, I look up at the hands of the clock.

Dear Gods above: a whole hour has passed. If I don't sleep now, dusk will overtake any chance of rest.

I run upstairs with the device in my hand, leaving the square pod and its tangled wires as the first decoration on my nightstand. My body is exhausted from all the fear, and I don't have to even draw the covers to find myself in slumber. I just collapse onto the bed, retreating into a deep sleep where the smoke of the cabin across the lake never reaches me.

My mind remembers the contours of Cody's body beneath the tattered shirt. I can't escape the thought in my dreams, no matter how much physical or mental furniture I pile against the sealed door.

ONE MONTH LATER

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02

KATIYA

There's no early breaks in all the domestic quests. It only took a couple days before I realized that sitting on the job was a bad image, unless you have a lunch pail in your hands. Just like any routine — whether it's a new cycle of combat training, classes, or a new job — the first three days are memorable because it's all so fresh. I thought taking different quests would make each day distinct from the last, but from the fourth day onward, it all became a blur of motion, forgotten at the end of each day by an exaspirated body and a tired mind.

This is the first job on city watch that has me raking leaves on the side. Though the mountainside is still flushed with fading green, the eager leaves transform from yellow to red and deposit themselves early on the stone thoroughfares. From a raised vantage point at the southwestern hillside of Gaffesend, I abate the stress by drawing in the crisp mountain air, watching as the browning wild lashes of the southern grasslands are battered about by gale winds.

Long in the distance, the grand lake reflects the shadowed mountain view, too far to make the crests of little waves. I watch as junior guards paddle back from their postings on the outer rim, wondering which of my friends are among them. But it's nice to know that at least I'm not alone.I've gotten to know her a lot better: the shy pair well with the timid since they end up taking similar tasks.

"When should we head down?" Naya asks.

"Well there's certainly no shortage of leaves, the Verdalan Gods make sure of it. Maybe now, I guess," I tell her. "This was all supposed to be done before the royals came to town, as if miles of road could be effectively polished by five junior guards."

"What does such a task even have to do with protecting?" Naya mutters.

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"We're protecting . . . the . . . image, I guess, of the city. And next we'll be protecting the parade route."

"Sometimes it feels like they're just trying to keep us busy with silly tasks," she says.

"It's allowed me to get to know the locals really well, at least. They say they're glad we take the tasks that make a difference."

"That's because you fawn for social interaction, it's quite marvelous to me how you're so full of energy all the time. But that's coming from someone who doesn't make friends unless they see them every day for about a month."

"A month?" The math surprises me. But it sounds about right when I count all the days I've taken off. I walk with Oriya, Jullian, Berry, and Ryder every morning for five of them, to take new postings from the quest board and get to work. Every sixth or so, I persuade them to join me on a hike or go swimming in the hot springs. And every night is my chance to get out and socialize when I'm not taking night quests: having only scouted twice, I feel quite distant from the others.

The loneliness carries into other areas, too. I've only seen Jullian five times since the start of this transition. Besides walking to work hand-in-hand, we've gotten together almost every day off to blow off some steam. I've only been able to convince him once to go on a date with me to the hot springs, and it was on my earnings. The other times he says he's too busy — though I always see him with his friends. It disappoints me when our acts of passion end as soon as he gets off: the only courtesy he seems to have is letting me get there first.

We descend the hill as the northern scouts congregate in Gaffesend Square. The bell tolls midday: normally that would mean a break for rations, but our service is expected to run later, and nobody minds when it makes this a "two-quest-day."

"I bet Bertram rues being sick when quest forms are this easy," I tell Naya. The slowness of this life almost makes me believe that Gaffe is as insular as the capital, capable of holding small events for royalty passing through the town. We're ordered to line up on the sides of the Main Street. It feels like a festival, the way all the street lamps are adorned with fresh

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flowers; the businesses shuttered for an hour; and the full population split between halves of the street. We stand in pattern between the onlookers and the empty road. The senior guards are busy on the city outskirts, demanding papers, and ensuring no Chymaeran spies are guising unwitting villagers. We hold the ceremonial rifles that we retrieved from the armory, clasped between our hands and upright, though Aldrin insists we "can't be fully trusted with them yet," and that we need to "train with a blade before we can handle them."

My eyes steady on the vacancy in front of me on the other side of the road, originally intended to be held by Bertram. Before long, the shimmering white carriage prattles down the road, drawn by two black horses. They're looking to have a two-nights'-stay in the hot springs, and we're meant to prove to them that Gaffesend is safe, encouraging more tourists to make the trek to enrich our lands.

I figure most of our population is excited for the presence of a Chosen Mask: we got the news that he was being paid to defend the carriage between villages. It's rare that anyone notable ever passes through, especially since we're the last stop before nothing. I can see him waving to his admirers from the coachman's seat as they cheer and throw flowers at the feet of the horses. Within the carriage, a finely-dressed family of six waves from the windows, wearing white and gold.

I feel my hands loosen their tension on the rifle. The nagging feeling of fear that's plagued me since forever is almost in the back seat, and around me, I can drink to the exuberance of the town. To my left, Naya smiles, predictably not the type to cheer. To my right, Pax pumps his fist in the air. And Bertram is absolutely focused on the royals, standing there directly in front of me.

The carriage is drawing closer, at least a hundred paces away. Some of the family's younger passengers have exited the carriage, walking alongside the road and tossing wrapped candies to the onlookers. The nagging feeling grows stronger. It's just too peaceful. And as my hands tension around the black steel, Bertram's eyes catch a glint of amethyst when he decides to make his move.

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03

KATIYA

They're close enough to run me over, but my body's trained to react before I can think. Muscle memory comes before thought, thought before fear, and fear before true reaction, so it's only when I'm halfway across the road that the thoughts finally reach my muscles. The others are only beginning to notice when the Chymaeran fleshwalker raises the rifle. I'm the only one that happened to know enough and be close enough to respond, and when I try to take another step, I feel the gravity of my past flood my veins with molasses.

I struggle to refuse the defenses of my own mind. I always swear I can taste the smoke from that fire when my heartbeat rises. And as the Chymaeran assassin guising my friend prepares to take aim and pull the trigger, all I can do is watch as I collapse to the street, giving the horses such a start that they shy and snort, rearing on their hind legs, casting the carriage forwards and backwards.

Pax is quick on the uptake: for every dearth of common sense, he excels in his perception, tuned to that energy of the attacker. While the other junior guards only begin to notice, and the Chosen is left helpless in a battle of speed, the assassin pulls the trigger, spooking the horses and the spectators as Pax tackles him to the ground.

I brace my head with my cheek brushing moss between the roadway stones. The coachman pulls the slip knot, and the horses' hooves clatter against the road, and I hold my breath, as if it could change the chances of the startled stallions shattering my spine or ribs. But they clamber right overhead, and as the carriage passes directly over my prostrated body lying straight with the road, I feel the wetness of something dense drip across my cheek.

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My ears still ring from the blast, but I can hear the cries of the children and the wife. And when I'm sure my whole body can still respond to its commands, I begin to crawl from beneath the carriage.

"May the gods damn your pathetic town and its useless guards," the wife says. "It should be wiped off the face of the map!"

I begin to imagine the repercussions, and I try to prepare myself for what's to come. I accept my fate to vanish from this program. I had my chance, and yet I couldn't even finish the job!

The Chosen drags me out from beneath the carriage with his gloved hands. A long streak of the husband's blood stains my bangs and trickles down my nose. When I look to the inside of the white carriage, emptied of its crying inhabitants and bright with a splatter of red, I find the husband taking shallow breaths as he holds his shoulder, tended to by the glowing hands of their family's hired healer.

The immaculately-dressed wife's jewelry clatters when she gets her hands around my collar, thrashing me as the Chosen hesitates to disarm his source of wealth. Her hands are already red with her lover's blood, clothes absent the pristine ivory white they surely struggled to sustain on such sultry trails.

"You cowering, yellow-bellied bitch," she exclaims. Her gloved hand batters my cheek with deafening leather contact. "You leach our tribute. You live to give your lives for us, and I'll be sure you don't see another sunrise in this line of work. The guard of this backwater town are a joke!"

I can feel my tears streaming, directly in the view of all my comrades that can only just stand there and watch. Jullian ducks his head when I meet his eyes. Naya freezes, her tail frayed. And Ryder and Pax are busy wrestling the Chymaeran as it tries to change forms.

But I hear the husband. "Dear. That young guard is the reason my head is on my shoulders. I mean, Gods, if she hadn't given the horses a start..."

"She nearly got you killed!"

"The bullet did that," he says.

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"But still," she says. The mercurial woman releases my collar and tensions her fists, letting out an exasperated cry. The side of my face aches as I slouch, wiping my tears with the unsullied parts of my arms, remembering not to dirty their carriage with contact from my body.

But it's the distress of the children that damages me the most. Standing on the other side of their life-altering trauma, facing such failure that I'm painted with the aggressor, the devastating shock registers on their faces, now devoid of sorrow, just speechless like I once was as they try to recalibrate their understanding of how horrifying the world can be. And all I want is to embrace them, to tell them that everything will be alright, to let them cry into my shoulder.

"You failed us. And you're going to pay for this," the wife screams at Aldrin when he approaches. "How are you going to make this right?"

"You'll make it right by apologizing to my officer," he says. "I don't care how much money you have, what role you play in the Empire, you will apologize for assaulting the woman who tried to save you!"

"And failed," she insists. "You're messing with Valensend blood—"

"You gave two days of warning for your arrival, refusing like all you rich types do to pay in advance, and then you have the gall to say we didn't prepare. It takes weeks!"

The woman tensions her fists. Two of children grasp her dress by the fabric. I draw deep breaths to make the blood flow back into my fingers and legs, all the while feeling like I'm stealing a resource I no longer deserve.

But I hear the father's voice behind me. "She would have complained the same if it was just a scare: I would have stopped her if I had the strength. As far as I'm concerned, you saved my life."

"But I hesitated. I saved no one. It was luck."

"Luck or not, you're a reason my children still have a father," he says. I turn around. He gestures for the servant and the healer to tend to my scratches, and with a quick wave of a hand, I feel the sting slowly dissipate from my face.

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He reaches from the open door, dabbing his blood from my skin with a clean corner of a towel, ensuring that nothing ill will come of this. Behind us, the two continue to argue as senior guards apprehend the battered Chymaeran assassin. It's only when I see the assailant's guise of my cherished friend that I remember the absence of the real one.

I release an unintelligible string of words before the panic peaks inside me once again. Aldrin shouts. Two of my friends try to stop me, and the woman screams of my cowardice, but all I can think of is what I learned it takes for a Chymaeran to steal a guise.

I run as fast as my feet will take me, choosing to try and save another, even if it means damnation for leaving this all behind.

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